

Five Things to Know about Notre Dame Cathedral

Notre Dame Cathedral in the French capital of Paris is set to reopen to the public Sunday after a five-year-long rebuilding project. The Cathedral had been badly damaged in a fire in 2019.

The Roman Catholic religious center is considered a jewel of Gothic building design, a symbol of Paris and is a popular site to visit.

The cathedral took 182 years to build between the 12th and 14th centuries. It holds some surprising stories. Here are five special things to know about this famous Parisian site:

The cathedral is considered France's geographic center.

In front of the cathedral, a metal and stone marker in the road describes the place as the "starting point of the roads of France." This sign marks the starting point for measuring distances between Paris and other cities across the country.

The marker was placed in 1924, but the idea of the cathedral as the center of the nation dates to 1769. King Louis XV thought there should be a central site for France's growing system of roads. That idea tied the nation's geography to its heart in Paris.

A view of the restored Notre-Dame cathedral Nov. 29, 2024, in Paris, France. (Christophe Petit Tesson, Pool via AP)

Its famous statues were added in the 19th century

Those frightening stone statues on Notre Dame might seem ancient, but not all of them are what they appear. The gargoyles are monster-shaped elements used to direct rainwater away from the building. They have been around since the time of the cathedral's construction. But the monster-like creatures often seen in photos and movies are chimera, and they are much newer.

In 1841, the French government asked the architects Eugène Viollet-le-Duc and Jean-Baptiste Lassus to repair the then-collapsing building. Viollet-le-Duc added these frightening-looking statues to make the cathedral seem more mysterious. He drew ideas for the chimera from Victor Hugo's famous book *The Hunchback of Notre Dame*.

How to tell them apart? Gargoyles resemble horizontal spikes coming out of the facade and have spouts to permit rainwater to flow out.

FILE - Preserved gargoyles of Notre-Dame de Paris cathedral are pictured, on April 17, 2019 in Paris. (AP Photo/Thibault Camus, File)

During the French Revolution, protesters changed Notre Dame.

During the French Revolution, there were protests of religious centers.

In 1793, revolutionaries took away the cathedral's religious symbols and renamed it "Notre-Dame de la Raison," or, in English, "Our Lady of Reason."

During that time, the cathedral held events celebrating science and new ideas and, for a short time, it was even used to store the alcoholic drink called wine.

Religious services started again in 1795 under the rule of Napoleon I.

FILE - Medieval sculptures of Notre-Dame cathedral's jube are displayed at the Cluny Museum, National Museum of the Middle Ages, in Paris, on Nov. 27, 2024. (AP Photo/Louise Delmotte, File)

Statues without heads were found and repaired.

In 1792, revolutionaries also cut the heads off 28 statues from the front of Notre Dame, thinking the statues were of French royalty. They were really representations of ancient kings of Judah, from stories in the Bible, the Christian holy book.

The heads were thought lost forever.

But in 1977, workers working in a courtyard in Paris uncovered hundreds of pieces of stone sculptures. Experts confirmed they were the missing heads of Notre Dame's kings of Judah statues.

Today, 22 of the heads have been repaired and are shown at the Cluny Museum in Paris.

FILE - Workers protective gear after a delay prompted by fears of lead contamination clean the area in front of Notre-Dame de Paris cathedral, on Aug. 19, 2019 in Paris. (AP Photo/Francois Mori, File)

The 2019 fire exposed a worldwide lack of outdoor lead pollution guidelines.

The 2019 fire that almost destroyed Notre Dame caused a serious health risk. When the flames melted the top of the building, large amounts of harmful lead dust were released into the air and came down across Paris.

Officials found there were no rules to measure the danger of outdoor lead dust. This was not just a Paris issue — major cities like London and Rome, and even the World Health Organization — do not have guidelines for outdoor lead pollution.

The Notre Dame fire forced officials to take a closer look at their safety standards. It took four months for the city to complete an extensive cleaning of the city's streets even as visitors and the citizens of Paris walked around the cathedral every day.

Now that you know these five things, you can enjoy seeing the photos of the new Notre Dame when it opens to the public.

I'm Caty Weaver.

Tom Nouvian reported this story for the Associated Press. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

symbol - n. สัญลักษณ์, เครื่องหมาย

gargoyle - n. รูปปั้นสัญลักษณ์ประดับรางน้ำบนหลังคาโบสถ์หรืออาคาร

chimera - n. สัตว์ประหลาดในเทพนิยายกรีกที่มีหัวเป็นสิงโต ตัวเป็นแพะ และหางเป็นงู ฟันไฟได้

resemble - v. คล้าย, เหมือน

horizontal - adj. แนวนอน, ขนานกับพื้น

spike - n. เหล็กแหลม, ตะปูขนาดใหญ่, แท่งแหลม

façade - n. ด้านหน้าอาคาร, ส่วนหน้า

spout - n. พวยกา, ปากท่อ, รางน้ำ

royalty - n. สมาชิกราชวงศ์, เชื้อพระวงศ์

courtyard - n. ลานบ้าน, ลานภายในอาคาร

flame - n. เปลวไฟ, เปลวเพลิง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. When is Notre Dame Cathedral set to reopen to the public after its rebuilding project?

In 2019

After a one-year project

On an unspecified Sunday in the future

This coming Sunday

2. Which of the following is NOT described as a characteristic or aspect of Notre Dame Cathedral?

A Roman Catholic religious center

A modern architectural masterpiece

A jewel of Gothic building design

A popular site to visit

3. How long did it take to construct Notre Dame Cathedral initially?

- Five years
- From the 12th to the 14th century
- 182 years
- Since 2019

4. What is Notre Dame Cathedral considered to be in relation to France's geography?

- Its historical monument
- Its cultural landmark
- Its geographic center
- Its religious capital

5. What is the primary function of the metal and stone marker in front of Notre Dame Cathedral?

- To signify the cathedral's age
- To mark the starting point for measuring distances across France
- To commemorate King Louis XV
- To direct tourists to the main entrance

6. When did the concept of Notre Dame as the nation's central site for roads first emerge?

- In 1924, when the marker was placed
- In 1769, proposed by King Louis XV
- During the 12th century, at its construction
- After the 2019 fire, as a new initiative

7. According to the article, when were Notre Dame's famous statues added?

- During the French Revolution
- In the 18th century
- In the 19th century
- After the 2019 fire

8. What is the primary functional difference between gargoyles and chimera, as described in the text?

- Gargoyles are ancient, while chimera are much newer.
- Chimera direct rainwater away from the building, whereas gargoyles are decorative.
- Gargoyles serve to direct rainwater, while chimera are primarily decorative statues.
- Gargoyles are monster-like figures, and chimera are human-like.

9. Who was primarily responsible for adding the frightening-looking chimera statues to Notre Dame Cathedral?

Victor Hugo

King Louis XV

Eugène Viollet-le-Duc

Jean-Baptiste Lassus

10. How can one distinguish gargoyles from other statues on the façade, according to the article?

They are always positioned at the very top of the spire.

They are painted in vibrant colors to stand out.

They resemble horizontal spikes and have spouts for rainwater.

They depict biblical figures and ancient kings.

11. During the French Revolution, what significant change did revolutionaries impose on Notre Dame Cathedral?

They refurbished its interior with modern art.

They restored its Gothic elements to their original state.

They removed its religious symbols and renamed it 'Our Lady of Reason'.

They converted it into a military barracks.

12. What unusual item was temporarily stored in Notre Dame Cathedral during the French Revolution?

Rare historical documents

Stolen artworks

Wine

Ancient religious artifacts

13. Why did revolutionaries cut the heads off 28 statues from the front of Notre Dame in 1792?

They believed the statues were representations of French royalty.

They wanted to simplify the cathedral's architectural style.

They were protesting against the Catholic Church's doctrines.

The statues were already severely damaged from neglect.

14. When and where were the missing heads of Notre Dame's kings of Judah statues finally discovered?

In 1792, immediately after they were cut off, but hidden.

In 1977, by workers in a courtyard in Paris.

During the clean-up after the 2019 fire.

In the 19th century, during a restoration project.

15. What significant environmental issue did the 2019 Notre Dame fire expose on a global scale?

The inadequacy of fire prevention measures in ancient buildings.

A worldwide lack of outdoor lead pollution guidelines.

The dangers of using lead in construction materials.

The slow response time of urban emergency services.